

1974 BCE

Babylon issues the first laws governing taverns

1634

Cole's Inn, Boston — first known licensed tavern in America

**1 PER 100
RESIDENTS**

Tavern density in early New England towns

8 MILES

Average distance between taverns on American stagecoach routes

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CHAOS MASTERY — 225 YEARS OF HOSPITALITY LEADERSHIP

SEAMLESSLY**CHAOS MASTERY**

FROM BABYLON TO BOSTON

WHERE IT ALL STARTED

Before there were restaurants, hotels, or venues, there were taverns — and before those, we felt obligated to feed and shelter travelers. Hospitality did not begin with a business model. It began as a moral obligation.

The earliest recorded hospitality laws come from Babylon, nearly 4,000 years ago. According to research compiled by Star Tavern, Babylonian law — **ordered the death penalty for vendors who diluted beer**. It was a moral framework: the host's obligation to the guest was sacred, and any violations was treated accordingly.^[1] startavern.net

In ancient Greece, this concept had a name: *xenia* — the sacred law of hospitality. Hosts were expected to welcome strangers, offer food and shelter, and refrain from asking where they came from or the purpose of their visit; until after they had been fed. According to HRC International's historical overview of the industry, the Greeks dedicated spaces — the *lesche*, meaning a place for council or conversation, and the *phatnai*, which provided spaces for locals, traders, diplomats, and public officials.^[7] hrc-international.com

The Roman twist: Early Roman taverns had a bad reputation; and prominent men shunned them (in public). This did not stop the upper classes — they entered in disguise. *Outcasts and troublemakers often filled these taverns, keeping them alive*

ANCIENT HOSPITALITY LAW

Babylonian law imposed the death penalty on tavern keepers who diluted beer — making good customer service a matter of life and death.

Source: Star Tavern — "What is a Tavern?" startavern.net

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Ancient civilizations with documented hospitality law: Babylon, Greece, Rome

HRC International, "History of the Hospitality Industry," hrc-international.com

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"Taverns and drinking establishments are almost as old as civilization itself. Some of the earliest records of tavern keeping involve Babylonian laws from nearly 4000 years ago."

STAR TAVERN

startavern.net — "What Is a Tavern?"

Greek hospitality law (*xenia*): To refuse shelter to a traveler was a religious offense in ancient Greece. Being hospitable was a non-negotiable — it was divine duty enforced by